

Green-Eyed Monster:

Envy, Contempt, and Loneliness in JD Salinger's *The Catcher in the Rye*

Resentment is drinking poison and hoping the other person will die. This idea of resentment's connection to self-destruction is prominent in J.D. Salinger's *The Catcher in the Rye*, which follows Holden Caulfield, a sixteen-year-old boy who was recently expelled from a prestigious prep school. He often observes the world around him and becomes envious of the seemingly uncomplicated lives of those he encounters. As the novel progresses, Holden grapples with shame, guilt, and envy, as he tries to find a place in society. Salinger employs diction and tone to illustrate Holden's envy leading to resentment of his peers and mentors, driving him to both push away and chase after them.

Holden's envy towards his peers causes him to feel contempt, ultimately leading to his isolation as he pushes the objects of his jealousy away. Throughout the novel, Holden experiences despair and melancholy. When his sister, Phoebe, comments that Holden doesn't like his life, Holden admits to his near-omnipresent feelings of apathy. His dissatisfaction with life leaves him open to envying what other people have and dragging down their accomplishments to make himself feel superior. Thus, his envy quickly turns to contempt. When Holden does not go out to the movies with some boys from Pencey, he narrates, "I didn't care about not seeing the movie, anyway. It was supposed to be a comedy, with Cary Grant in it, and all that crap. Besides, I'd been to the movies with Brossard and Ackley before. They both laughed like hyenas at stuff that wasn't even funny. I didn't even enjoy sitting next to them in the movies" (37). Holden says Ackley and Brossard "laughed like hyenas," disparaging their behavior. The word "hyenas" has an animalistic connotation: while Holden could have compared the two to anything, he chose an animal often characterized as wild or savage. This choice illustrates how at this moment, Holden

views Ackley and Brossard as below him—as animals. However, Salinger implies that he is actually envious of the two for their carefree nature and ability to make friends. The stark contrast between what he does—inviting Ackley to the movies—and what he says—saying they “laugh like hyenas”—shows how Holden is an unreliable narrator. He lies to himself until he is willing to push others away for the sole purpose of protecting his own image. Holden also antagonizes the women from the Lavender Room, whom he envies for their friendship with each other. He narrates that he “could hardly stop [himself] from giving her a kiss on the top of her [one of the women’s] dopey head” (72). His tone in this quote is extremely condescending and rude: he infantilizes these women, calling one of them “dopey.” When he dances with them, Holden acts surprised that they’re good at it. These details convey his superiority and their inferiority, but Salinger implies that Holden’s shaming of them is just a coping mechanism. The phrase “could hardly stop myself” contrasts his narrative of superiority. Holden could not stop himself from kissing her, a physical manifestation of his longing for connection, despite his clearly demeaning language. He reveals his true feelings when he narrates, “The funny thing is, I thought she was enjoying it too...” (71). This shows how Holden craved connection with the Lavender Room women, but chooses to deliberately push them away by caricaturing them in his mind as “dopey.” Moreover, the tone of the word “funny” would usually connote unimportance, but it takes on a new meaning in this quote. Salinger purposefully uses this word to point out that Holden is ignorant of his own paradoxical emotions: he calls it funny that he thought they were enjoying themselves, but in reality it is deeply sad. Holden truly believed he was forming a connection, despite his age difference and lack of maturity, but that fantasy was ripped away from him. He says it was “funny,” as a way to cope, unwilling to face the reality of his

loneliness. Holden's envy of both his fellow students at Ackley and the Lavender Room women leads him to either push them away or degrade them, isolating himself in the process.

However, Holden's envy often leads him to yearn for connection, despite him pushing away the very same people he wants to grow closer to. For example, when Holden is at Pencey he invites Ackley to the movies, saying "I asked Mal if he minded if Ackley came along with us..." (36). Holden invites Ackley, who is the target of his contempt throughout the early chapters of the novel. This is a deliberate choice from Salinger because it shows how Holden is desperate for connection with even those he resents. The fact that he asks before inviting Ackley is telling as well, because it shows how Holden is considerate towards his peers, despite the apathetic image he tries to display. He wants the childlike innocence of "laughing like hyenas" and even though he says the opposite, Holden wants people to go to the movies with. He uses his contempt as an excuse so he does not have to face his own loneliness. In an attempt to avoid this isolation, Holden goes to the Lavender Room, a popular bar. When he is there, the sixteen-year-old flirts with three older women, but reveals his envy of their friendship and his own desire for meaningful relationships. Just before he leaves the Lavender Room, Holden apologizes "like a madman" (73). Despite his envy and disparaging remarks, Holden desperately tries to keep his relationship with these women intact. Salinger's choice of the word "madman" clearly depicts Holden's need for connection: he could have compared Holden to anything else, but the irrational and severe connotations that come with the word "madman" fit Holden in this situation. He seeks out relationships with people he is contemptuous towards because ultimately, his own self-image is just as low as his perceptions of them. Salinger exemplifies this idea through the duality of Holden's contempt and longing for the Lavender Room women. Holden's crazed state implies that he is expressing his true feelings, rather than a mask he puts up to

defend himself, yet his yearning for an emotional bond is rejected, as the women leave and the bar closes. His envy towards Ackley and the Lavender Room women, which originally manifests as contempt, is sublimated to a need for connection.

Holden's diction and tone throughout *Catcher in the Rye* suggest that his envy creates a paradox of pushing those he is jealous of away while simultaneously yearning for their affection. People like Holden, who are unable to process complex and intertwined emotions, are left on the sidelines. Holden feels uniquely alone and transient: he is stuck between the comforts of childhood and the freedom of adulthood, living in what he views as the worst of both worlds. He longs for connection but is unable to find it. Holden Caulfield's mind is poisoned by the green-eyed monster that is envy, and the only antidote is time.